the Chinese by the British Liaison in Beijing, on the question of Britain recognizing the new regime in China. On 16 January 1950 (one day prior to Nehru's message to Zhou Enlai), Callaghan had told the Chinese Foreign Ministry that Great Britain regarded the exchange of letters between the two governments as constituting the establishment of diplomatic relations, and that there was no further matter to discuss in this regard other than the technicalities relating to the exchange of Ambassadors. [31] Liu Shaoqi told Mao and other Chinese leaders that the similarity in the positions of India and Great Britain suggested the possibility of collusion between them. In his view, the British were using India to test the waters on whether China would seek concessions on substantive issues like Hong Kong from Britain as part of the process of diplomatic recognition. [32]

After deliberating over Liu Shaoqi's concerns about possible Anglo-Indian collusion, Mao, who was away in Moscow, felt that it was even more important to pay close attention to the negotiations with India, because it would become a template for all subsequent negotiations on diplomatic relations with non-socialist countries, including with Great Britain. Mao made three phone calls to Liu Shaoqi on 20 January 1950 on this matter. [33] It was decided that China should not display any anxiety or eagerness to discuss or resolve substantive issues, or else India and Britain might try to leverage diplomatic relations to extract Chinese concessions on issues like Hong Kong or Tibet. Mao decided to take advantage of India's keenness to establish relations in order to secure other objectives. On Mao's personal direction, a reply to Nehru's letter of 17 January 1950 was sent by Vice Foreign Minister Li Kenong on 20 January 1950. It stated that there was no important issue that needed to be negotiated before the exchange of ambassadors. Nehru took this to mean that Tibet would not be discussed. But he failed to